

## Peer Review: Discourse Community Assignment

A group of people can make a community. They might share similar interests, or they may live in the same town. But beyond that simplistic idea of community, there is something called a “discourse community.” There are several criteria for a simple group of people to become a discourse community. These criteria, as defined by John Swales, and paraphrased by Mezler (2020), are:

1. A broadly agreed upon set of common public goals
2. Mechanisms of intercommunication among members
3. Use of these communication mechanisms to provide information and feedback
4. One or more genres that help further the goals of the discourse community
5. A specific Lexis (specialized language)
6. A threshold level of expert members (24-26) (p. 102).

These six criteria ensure that the members of the community are active participants; they collaborate and communicate with one another (they have discourse). These communities need to be able to grow, to learn off of each other, and to expand their niches beyond just an insular group. I of course am a part of a discourse community. I could just say that discourse community is “retro computing,” as in people who collect and mess with obsolete computers, but that’s too vague. There are just too many different types of retro computing enthusiasts. Take for instance, users on the online forum Reddit, who make up the “subreddit” r/amiga. The group very clearly has a common set of public goals, as stated by the subreddit’s description: “We talk about relevant news, events, new and old hardware and software and all things Commodore Amiga” (r/amiga, 2008). Even though a user in r/amiga and me are into old computers, we aren’t in the

same discourse community, as we aren't interested into the same type of old computers and are unlikely to interact because of it.

### **What is my discourse community?**

Now back to figuring out my discourse community. My Amiga example proves there needs to be specific interests, along with a shared method of communication where members know where to hold discourse. The discourse community I'm choosing has both those criteria, along with the rest defined by Swales. It's an online group I found through an event, with the goal providing a private "retro internet" for old, unsecured computer systems. The community interacts in a Discord server owned by the founder and leader of the project. When not using the retro network, the Discord server has many different channels for members to ask for help, suggest changes to the retro network, discuss other retro tech topics, or just hang out. Even though most of the inter-member discussion happens through the Discord server, there are semi-active voice-chats where members get to interact without using text, there are many different games running on the retro network where, of course, the members play video games together, and there are alternate text-based communication methods present in the community. As a tech community, specialized languages are in abundance. Members need to have at least a basic understanding of IP networks, along with routers and VPNs to even be able to participate in the main goal of the community, to join the retro network. And I couldn't even avoid the acronyms when giving a surface-level explanation. And finally there are plenty of expert community members; from the multiple popular retro computing YouTube personalities, to the enthusiasts employing every obsolete networking standard in their home networks. Let's expand on these ideas.

### **A broadly agreed upon set of common public goals**

Here's the idea behind the community: The modern Internet is not friendly to old computers and especially old operating systems. Those old web browsers don't support modern JavaScript-heavy websites or modern security protocols. Connecting an older device to the internet can be a major security hole. So a project was created to have a closed off public network only for these obsolete systems. The founder of the project, as known by his handle Cursed Silicon, states in part on his personal wiki page for the project: "Compu-Global-Hyper-Mega-Net is not accessible by the wider internet and is specifically designed to be a hermetically sealed network. Users can only connect via the above methods and can only communicate with other devices on the network" (n.d.). To avoid the security problems with connecting an older system to the modern internet, the "Compu-Global-Hyper-Mega-Net" is a fully closed off network that requires prospective users to sign up and it's the only way they can be let in. When describing his discourse community, Melzer says that his community also has a website declaring its goals. These goals were "having fun, enjoying the music, and learning new songs," but more importantly these goals proved that the community was more than just "'Guitar players' or 'people who like music' or even 'guitarists in Sacramento, California'" (2020, p. 102). It's the same idea with my community's stated goals; we're more than a random group of people who like old Macs and Windows XP, we're a group of people who participate in the "Compu-Global-Hyper-Mega-Net," and we collaborate to make it better.

### **Mechanisms of intercommunication among members**

## References

r/amiga. (2008, Jun 6). *Subreddit description*. Reddit. <https://www.reddit.com/r/amiga/>

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